

An Argument for Habitual Self-Silencing

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When a speaker stops themselves from saying specific things, this can be considered a case of self-silencing. It is difficult to align cases of self-silencing with maxims of other forms of silencing that are based on external intervention. To further understand the mechanism for self-silencing, this paper will 1) present a conventional definition of self-silencing in M.K. McGowan's book "On Silencing" as a decision against speaking, which this essay calls *intentional self-silencing*; 2) propose an alternative type of self-silencing without an intentional choice against a particular speech act, which this essay calls *habitual self-silencing*; 3) provide a framework to identify *habitual self-silencing*.

Speech Act and Communication-Prevention Silencing

Speech act theory is one of the most important concepts in the silencing literature. It explains how people can perform actions with utterance in virtue of the utterance functioning as speech. (McGowan 22) For example, when the commanding officer says "shoot him", his words act as a command to his soldiers to shoot. In a speech act, the action that the speaker performs in saying something is defined as an illocution, in other words, the speaker's intended action with their utterance. (Austin 99) Illocution is different from the causal effect of one's speech on its audience, which is defined as perlocution. In the case of the commanding officer, his perlocution is the soldiers firing their guns. Some illocutions can be simple assertions of descriptions or beliefs, and others can be more complicated, such as refusals or commands, as with the commanding officer. Consider an example of a researcher presenting her work at a conference. The researcher says "silencing is an important area of studies in philosophy of language," by which she makes an assertion to her audience on the importance of her research focus. Consider another example of a celebrity who says, "No, I am already at capacity" to an invitation to a

philanthropic event. She performs a rejection with her words to those who extended the invitation. Speech acts are fundamental building blocks for us to understand communication between speakers. This essay will now introduce silencing, which captures cases of unfair or failed communication.

Silencing can take various forms across different stages of communication. In McGowan's book "On Silencing: What It Is and Why It Matters?", silencing takes place through:

1) *communication prevention*: before a communication attempt, i.e., preventing the communication attempt from happening;

2) *recognition failure*: during the communication, i.e., preventing the audience from recognising the speaker's speech act;

3) *impact prevention*: after the communication, i.e., preventing the speaker's intended impact of their speech act from taking place. (McGowan 48)

Take the example of *Duct Tape: an annoyed parent covering their child's mouth with duct tape*. The duct tape physically prohibits the child from making any sound, which means that the child can not utter or make actions with her words. This is a case of *communication prevention* where external interventions prevent communication attempts by making them physically impossible. Unlike the *Duct Tape* example, where an external force prohibits the speaker from communicating, this essay focuses on self-silencing, where the speaker is prevented from performing a speech act due to their own internal considerations. With the focus on self-silencing, this essay takes on a partial definition of silencing as *communication prevention*, investigating cases where these communication preventions are imposed by the speakers themselves without external interventions.

Intentional Self-Silencing

In M.K. McGowan's book "On Silencing", self-silencing is defined as the speaker's decision against performing a certain speech act. McGowan's understanding of self-silencing necessitates a harm-avoidant condition where the self-silenced speaker wants to avoid the anticipated harms of performing an intended speech act. This essay addresses cases of self-silencing that fulfill this definition as *Intentional Self-silencing*, which requires the following three necessary conditions:

1. **Intention:** The speaker has an originally intended speech act.
2. **Harm Avoidance:** The speaker wants to avoid the anticipated harm of performing the intended speech act.
3. **Choice:** The speaker chooses against performing the intended speech act.

This essay will evaluate different cases of communication by whether they fulfill the three conditions of intentional self-silencing. Consider the following example: **Performative Patriot:** *Leah, a government official, feels that her colleagues are avoiding her in the office. She suspects that people are distancing themselves from her due to her opinion against military parades. This anti-government opinion is unpopular in her office. Leah does not like to be further isolated at work. Every time she wants to share her opinion on military parades, she is reminded of her isolated situation and decides to either not speak at all or speak in support.*

Leah has a speech act she intends to perform: to assert her disagreement with military parades. She anticipates that her colleagues might go on to isolate her in the office, which negatively impacts her comfort at work and even hinders workplace collaborations. Leah wants to avoid the aforementioned harms, so she chooses against asserting her disagreement. Leah may completely withhold from performing any speech act, or go ahead with an alternative of

celebrating military parades with her colleagues. In both cases, she decides against making the speech act she originally intended to perform.

We have to acknowledge that the harm that Leah anticipates for her intended speech act may not actually occur. For example, Leah's colleagues can avoid speaking to her, not because of her anti-government political opinions, but because they are planning a secret birthday prank for her. They are scared that they might accidentally reveal the secret if they speak to her. In this case, when Leah asserts her opinions against military parades, her colleagues do not take them seriously and judge her by them, so the harm Leah anticipates will not happen. Different from the actual harm that will take place, the ***harm avoidance*** condition focuses on the speaker's motivation to avoid a potential harm that they perceive and predict.

This essay considers the ***harm avoidance*** condition satisfied as long as the speaker anticipates negative impacts that they would like to avoid. Consider the case that Leah suffers from delusions of persecution, which makes her predictions for the future always negative. We can argue that Leah's harm anticipations, in this case, are pathological and not well evidenced. This leads to the complex question of how much warrant a speaker needs for their harm anticipation to be considered reasonable. While acknowledging the importance of the warrant, this essay assumes that all harm anticipations are well-warranted because the speaker has the best knowledge of their situation, and will not go into depth on this assumption. Therefore, as long as Leah anticipates the harm and avoids making her intended speech act because of it, her case fulfills the ***harm avoidance*** condition of intentional self-silencing.

Leah's case fulfills all conditions for intentional self-silencing. Consider another case that does not align perfectly with the three conditions of intentional self-silencing: ***Born Patriot:*** *George grew up in a very patriotic family, watching TV shows and listening to bedtime stories*

about their country's great wars. When George was younger, he was severely penalised by his family for asking questions that challenged the national army. Young George decided that he should no longer ask these questions. As George grew up, he slowly normalised not asking questions in political conversations to avoid being condemned and penalized like before. Now, after many years, George no longer considers the potential harm of questioning propaganda in conversations. He just agrees with others as a natural response.

We can separate George's communicative attempts into two stages: the first stage is when he was younger, soon after being penalised by his family; the second stage is the current stage. George's case in the first stage aligns with conditions of intentional self-silencing. He found himself penalised as a consequence of asking anti-propaganda questions. As a young child, he internalised the harm he received and made it his own responsibility not to repeat this speech act to avoid further harm. As a result, he repeatedly chose against asking political questions to avoid being penalised by his family or other members of his audience.

I would like to focus on the second case, which does not align with McGowan's framework for self-silencing. In this case, George's communication attempts no longer fulfil the **choice** condition (3), which requires a speaker to decide against an intended speech act. This explicit decision between speech acts is an internal thought process that occurs before the speaker commits to a particular speech act. Adult George does not consider the option of asking challenging questions in political conversations in the moment before he commits to agreeing with his interlocutors. In fact, agreement becomes a natural speech act he performs without second thought. Therefore, in the second case, George does not deliberately choose against another speech act he intended to perform, which is required as a necessary condition for intentional self-silencing.

Meanwhile, the *intention* and *harm avoidance* (1) (2) condition of intentional self-silencing still applies to this case. Even in the second case of adult George, the alternative speech act of questioning still exists, but is no longer part of George's consideration before he speaks. Similarly, the condition of harm anticipation is still present in George's case, but in a different way than in Leah's example, *Performative Patriot*. Rather than being foregrounded in the speaker's decision-making process, harm anticipation acts as a context for George's speech act. The harm of being penalised by his family motivated George's intentional self-silencing in his childhood. As an adult, it became less of a choice and more of a reflex as he no longer spent time evaluating the potential harms before performing the speech act of agreement. The harm he anticipated from past trauma gradually became an internalised belief that he stopped questioning or actively thinking about.

The adult George's case diverges from the requirements for intentional self-silencing. The speaker does not choose against a particular speech act. In fact, speakers like grown George do not consider the alternative speech act as an option before speaking. The harm anticipation and alternative speech act conditions for intentional self-silencing only appear as implicit context, instead of being a part of their explicit decision-making. This essay argues that adult George's case should be considered as a different category of self-silencing.

This essay contends that the element of harm remains necessary in this new category of self-silencing. Consider a counterexample: *Good Vibe Patriot*: *George's family is always excited watching propaganda films and reading war stories. Young George is confused why his country kills people from other places, but he never remembers to ask his family in the moment because he is also enjoying the good vibes.* In this case, George has not considered the potential consequences of asking his family anti-propaganda questions, so his lack of expression is not

motivated by the potential harm. His choice to enjoy the patriotic discussions with his family occurs simply because he enjoys the ambience. Without anticipation or belief in potential harm, *Good Vibe Patriot* does not fall under intentional self-silencing, nor the new category of self-silencing this essay proposes.

In the following section, I am going to consider the cases similar to *Born Patriot* that do not fulfill the choice condition for intentional self-silencing. This essay argues for these cases to form a new category of self-silencing called habitual self-silencing, where the speaker still silences themselves without choosing against an intended speech act.

Habitual Self-Silencing

Habitual self-silencing accounts for when the speaker performs speech acts without active decision-making in the moment of speaking. The process of learning to self-silence and normalising it as a habit can be found in other activities where people learn and form habits through repetition and reinforcement. For example, when learning piano, beginners spend time training to hold the ideal piano hand shape of a relaxed “C”. As pianists spend more time advancing their skills, they stop actively trying to hold the perfect hand shape when playing. The “C” hand shape simply becomes natural to them.

Not just an active choice against a particular speech act, this essay argues that self-silencing in communication can be carried out as a practice of habits that come from an internalised belief of harm. These cases, where the speaker naturally performs speech acts just as a practiced piano hand shape, are different from intentional self-silencing, where the speaker takes time to think and makes a deliberate choice right before committing to a speech act. This essay continues to differentiate intentional and habitual self-silencing through comparative examples, and then defines and proposes a framework for habitual self-silencing.

Consider the following example: ***I wish I could help, but I don't want to:** Phoebe is asked by her underage friend to help buy alcohol for Marathon Monday. Phoebe does not want to do her a favor. She proceeds to...* This essay will show two different scenarios in Phoebe's case that correspond respectively with intentional self-silencing and habitual self-silencing. Firstly, consider the case where Phoebe makes an intentional decision:

***Anticipated Politeness:** Phoebe recalls that her friend takes rejection seriously, so she decides to come up with an excuse instead of directly rejecting her. She tells her friend that she is having a headache, so her friend doesn't take it personally.*

This case falls under intentional self-silencing. Phoebe considers the speech act of directly rejecting her friend, such as saying "no, I don't want to". However, she anticipates that her friend would be upset by a blunt rejection and even think that Phoebe has an issue with her, which could harm the relationship between the two of them. Therefore, Phoebe decides that she should avoid the undesirable consequences by performing another speech act, indirect refusal through an excuse. Excuses are complicated speech acts, and this essay adopts a simplified understanding of excuse as an assertion with implication, in which case Phoebe asserts to her friend that she is sick while implying that she rejects the friend's request.

Consider a second case where Phoebe goes through a different thought process:

***Habitual Politeness:** Phoebe has learned growing up that it's impolite and wrong to reject other people directly. Her parents told her so, and she observed that adults around her never directly rejected each other. Through these exposures, Phoebe grew into a habit of coming up with polite excuses as rejections. In this conversation with her friend, she naturally came up with a polite excuse of a headache as a response to a request she doesn't want to fulfill.*

The difference between this case and *Anticipated Politeness* is that Phoebe did not consider other speech acts or perform a cost-benefit analysis between options before she made her excuse. Phoebe found politeness a prevalent norm in her upbringing. Disobeying these politeness norms can lead to being deemed as rude, which can be especially harmful for a woman like Phoebe in society. She learned to follow social conventions of polite actions and speech, through which she internalised the etiquette of using excuses as indirect refusals. In one case, Phoebe might have first had to actively remind herself against direct refusals and slowly build the habit of indirect refusals. In another case, she might have never even considered saying “no” as an option when refusing other people. Either way, Phoebe built a habit of indirect refusals, which she naturally practices without making new deliberate decisions before speaking each time. This case can be considered as habitual self-silencing.

After introducing the concept of habitual self-silencing in contrast to intentional self-silencing, this essay proposes the following necessary conditions for performing habitual self-silencing:

1. ***Belief of Harm***: The speaker believes that performing a certain speech act has harmful consequences.
2. ***Habit***: The speaker forms a habit of not performing a particular speech act.
3. ***Application***: The speaker performs speech acts in accordance with their habit.

Recall George’s case in *Born Patriot*, which shows how intentional self-silencing can grow into habitual self-silencing as the speaker slowly internalises a communication habit. George experienced harm from asking anti-propaganda questions and believes that the same harm will recur if he performs the same speech act. Through active reinforcements, he forms a habit of not asking anti-propaganda questions and applies it in conversations. As time goes on,

George habitually silences himself without making any intentional decisions. Therefore, the case of George begins with intentional self-silencing and then becomes fully habitualised.

There is another case of habitual self-silencing that does not involve intentional self-silencing at any point, where the speaker never considered a particular speech act as a possible alternative due to deep-seated beliefs of harm. Phoebe's case in *Habitual Politeness* falls under this category, since she never considers direct refusals viable responses to an unpleasant request. Her belief in direct refusal as impolite cultivates a habit of indirect refusals, which she naturally practices when turning down her friend. Consider another example of habitual self-silencing without any previous intentional decisions:

***Secret Mole:** Ash was brought up in a country where individuals with moles are discriminated against. He notices that no one around him shares publicly about their moles, and the ones who people know for having moles are treated terribly. Ash has a mole under his hair that no one knows about. Ash never considered the speech act of disclosing his mole to other people as a possible option. As a result, he never tells anyone about his mole. He naturally remains silent when his friends laugh at people with moles and even lies that he doesn't have a mole to his physician during mandatory checkups.*

In this example of habitual self-silencing, Ash builds a habit against asserting that he has a mole due to negative social stereotypes and a lack of positive role models. The negative stereotypes about people with moles perpetuate harmful consequences, which can include physical violence, passive aggression, and discrimination against them. Ash, as part of the social group being discriminated against, believes that the same harm would befall him if he publicly discloses his identity. This fulfills the ***belief of harm*** condition, since Ash anticipates direct harm of discrimination from discussing his mole with others. Not only does Ash have a deep belief

that public knowledge about his mole will inevitably lead to harm, but Ash has also never seen people making attempts to assert the fact that they have moles and talk about their moles. Therefore, Ash never considered disclosing his mole as a viable alternative speech act in his communication with others.

Ash naturally forms a habit of performing other speech acts other than sharing about his mole, which fulfills the *habit* condition. Ash proceeds to perform a series of different speech acts in accordance with his habit. In the example, Ash sometimes simply abstains from the conversation and remains silent. He sometimes performs complex speech acts such as lying. Either way, Ash doesn't consider sharing about his mole as an alternative speech act to even perform, which is a natural *application* of his habit. Therefore, the example of Ash fulfills all three necessary conditions for habitual self-silencing.

After defining and providing three conditions for habitual self-silencing, the essay will discuss the significance of habitual self-silencing. Compared to intentional self-silencing, it offers a more practical understanding of our decision-making process during conversations. Intentional self-silencing requires the speaker to perform dedicated decision-making before attempting any speech act. Careful deliberation is energy-consuming and complex. It oftentimes doesn't actively take place before the speaker commits to each speech act in communication, especially when the conversation runs at a fast pace or when the speaker doesn't have the mental capacity. Intentional self-silencing applies best to cases with high stakes or special occasions, such as job interviews and taking testimonies, but it has limitations in daily interactions. The concept of habitual self-silencing provides conceptual tools for us to understand social norms or our own communication habits in these more minute instances, such as conversations with friends or a writing assignment.

The wide array of examples in this essay demonstrates how building habits of self-silencing can be harmful to the speaker. To mitigate the harm of habitual self-silencing, I suggest starting by recognising when our own communication habits are motivated by harm anticipation and avoidance. George's example explains how habits can be informed through negative personal experiences such as childhood trauma. Phoebe and Ash's examples explain how habits are influenced by dominant social norms. Habitual self-silencing can be harder to catch than intentional self-silencing, since it comes so naturally and intuitively without deliberation before each communication attempt. I encourage everyone to reflect on what personal experiences and social conventions inform our communication styles.

Conclusion

This essay starts with introducing concepts of speech act theory and communication prevention silencing, which entails self-silencing as a subcategory. By the definition and necessary conditions of intentional self-silencing, this essay argues that self-silencing takes place even without an intentional decision against a particular speech act. With examples of speakers naturally practicing a habit of not performing a particular speech act, this essay identifies a new category of self-silencing called habitual self-silencing and proposes a three-condition framework for it.

Works Cited

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